STATE SCAN

J&K: UPPER HOUSE, UPPER CUT PG 16 | KERALA: WAYANAD SURVIVORS FACE APATHY PG 20



FRESH MOBILISATION Mayawati and nephew Akash Anand at a BSP event to mark Kanshi Ram's death anniversary, Lucknow, Oct. 9

SUMIT KUMAR

▶ UTTAR PRADESH

ANTI-SLIP TURF FOR MAYAWATI

Out of power for 15 years, and facing an erosion to her base from SP-Congress as well as new Dalit voices, the ex-CM's 'comeback' is a grim attempt to hold on

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

IT'S NEVER A BAD TIME TO OBSERVE THE DARK IRONIES of Dalit politics in Uttar Pradesh. On October 1, in Rae Bareli, a young Dalit was lynched on suspicion of being a thief. A piece of ritual-like debasement came 20 days later: an elderly Dalit allegedly forced to lick his own urine off the ground near a temple at Kakori, outside Lucknow. On October 9, bracketed between those two events, Lucknow saw a rally—moving to its own inner logic, in another orbit.

Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) supremo Mayawati, long-time patent-holder of Dalit representation, was making her first big address since 2021. Visually, her army conquered Lucknow: some 200,000 BSP workers, in blue *gamchas* and waving their blue flag, streamed in. The Kanshi Ram Memorial ground ran out of space. On the eponymous party founder's death anniversary, his protégée was making a rare statement.

BUT WHAT'S THE GAME?

Context, they say, is everything. By next October, as UP enters the home stretch for the 2027 assembly election, Kanshi Ram would have been a memory for 20 years. Mayawati would be going on 71, her last stint in power also a fading memory. In